

THE BLACK PANTHER

INTERCOMMUNAL NEWS SERVICE
PUBLISHED WEEKLY BY THE BLACK PANTHER PARTY

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VOL. XVI NO. 25

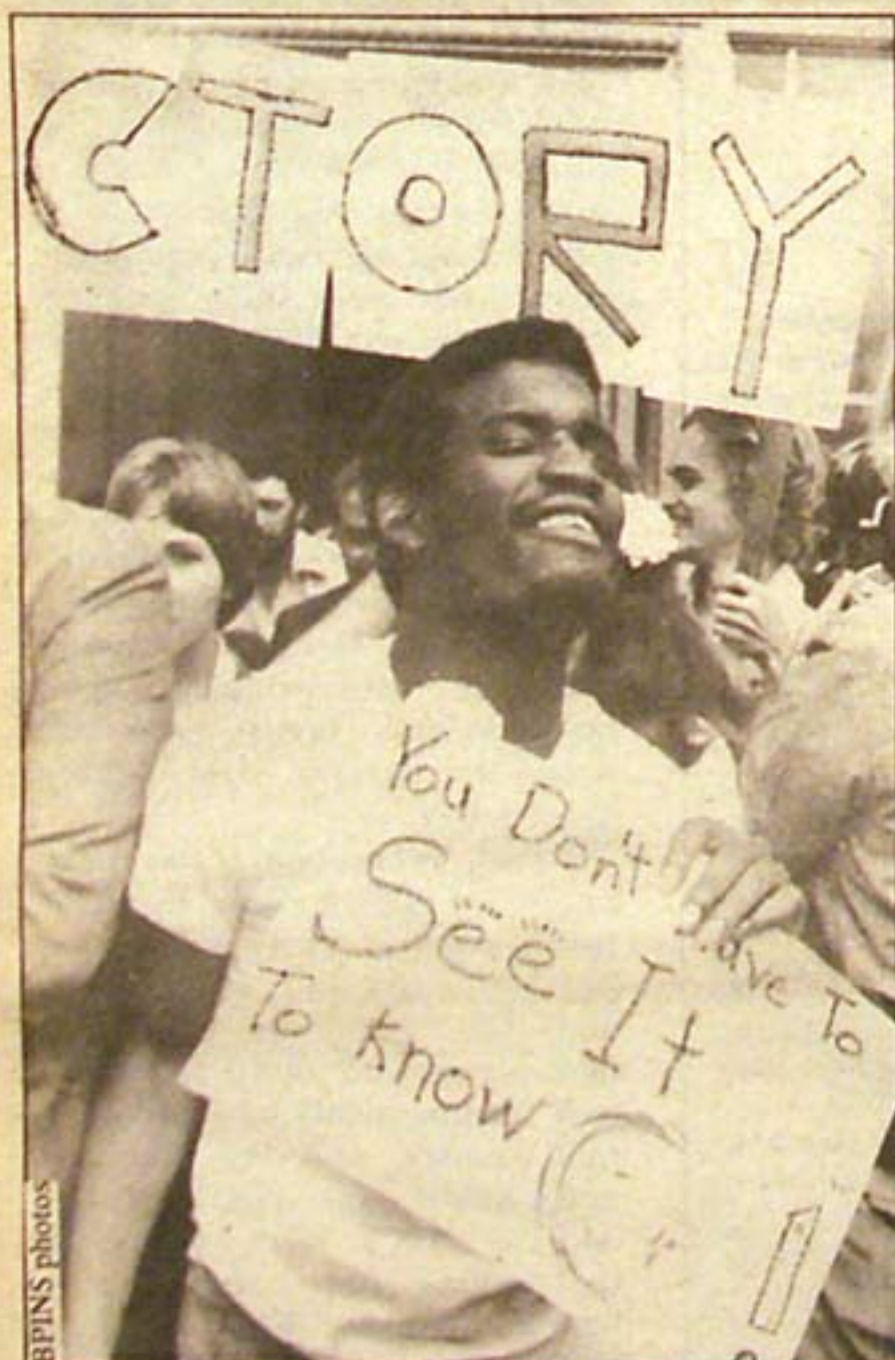
SATURDAY, MAY 7, 1977

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Pressure Forces Califano To Sign 504 Regulations

HANDICAPPED WIN DEMANDS- END H.E.W. OCCUPATION



(San Francisco, Calif.) - "We Have Overcome — can you hear it — We Have Overcome," said the final group of handicapped and disabled people returning from Washington, some with wide smiles, others with lingering tears, bunched together in the airport lobby.

"We Have Overcome," they sang to the depths of their hearts, just as their counterparts had sung that same tune before ending their triumphant 26-day sit-in.

It was their unofficial theme song, once a source of hope and inspiration, now transformed to coincide with their tremendous victory, just as their powerful protest will soon transform the face of America.

In truth, the wheelchair-confined and disabled people who successfully took on the federal government — occupying the Health, Education and Welfare (HEW) offices in San Francisco for nearly four weeks, while sending a delegation to Washington, D.C., to directly confront their oppressors — had overcome, and, indeed, their message was heard across the land.

On Thursday, April 28, HEW Secretary Joseph Califano, signed into law the far-reaching Section 504 of the Vocational Rehabilitation Act of 1973, thus barring discrimination against disabled people in all buildings and facilities receiving federal funds.

The signing of the long-delayed implementation regulations was the significant victory the handicapped and disabled had sought in

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Blind demonstrator DENNIS BILLUPS (left) and other protesters triumphantly ended their 26-day sit-in at San Francisco's HEW offices last week. Black Panther Party members CHUCK JACKSON and BRAD LOMAX (top, photo) played an integral role in this strategic struggle for human rights.